

Amanda Traylor

How Amanda Traylor Is Rebuilding What Leadership Looks Like in a Rural Texas District

There is a version of educational leadership that sounds impressive in a press release. It has a strategic vision, transformational outcomes, and stakeholder alignment.

But then there's the reality of running a small, rural district in Texas, where you see your staff at church, run into parents at the post office, and where every decision ends up on the desks of just five people, with everyone knowing each other's business.

Amanda Traylor lives in this world. Her leadership is clear-eyed, consistent, and surprisingly unglamorous, which says more about what true school leadership requires than most frameworks ever could.

A New Role Without a Heads-up

When Amanda first stepped into the superintendent role, the biggest problem wasn't a budget gap or a curriculum issue. It was culture. Specifically, a culture in which a small group of people had become comfortable controlling decisions, influencing outcomes, and, at times, making others feel that staying quiet was the safer choice.

That kind of thing is hard to name. Harder to confront. But she knew that nothing else could change until that did.

"Before we could move forward strategically, we had to reset expectations," she says. "I've always operated under a simple motto: work hard and be nice to people. It sounds straightforward, but it sets a clear standard. We are here to put in the work for students every single day, and we will treat one another with professionalism and respect as we do so. Both matter equally."

That meant honest conversations and making clear that influence in this district would come from contribution, not control. And in some cases, it meant making difficult staffing decisions. Those decisions weren't personal. They were about protecting the people who'd been sidelined, the ones who'd quietly stopped raising their hands.

There was a reset period. It required steadiness and consistency to get through it. But once alignment took hold, the shift was real. Morale improved. Collaboration followed. Not because of pressure, but because people felt safe enough to show up.

What "Building Together" Actually Means

One of the things Amanda changed early was how decisions got made. Not just what decisions, but the process around them.

She stopped presenting finished plans. Started building them with people instead.

"In a 1A district, people don't just want to know what the decision is, they want to understand why," she explains. "When we began clearly communicating the reasoning behind major initiatives, we saw trust grow. Even when people didn't fully agree, they understood the direction and the purpose."

When her district was developing a new strategic plan, they didn't draft it in a conference room and roll it out. They surveyed everyone: staff, parents, students, and community members. Asked what they cared about and what they wanted graduates of the district to leave with. Then they built the mission and vision from those answers.

"Listening to every voice creates ownership," she says. "When people can see themselves in the mission, alignment follows naturally."

It's simple, yet uncommon. Most leaders recognize they should take this step but often avoid it because it feels slow, chaotic, and unproductive. Amanda chose to embrace the slow, chaotic process because she believed it was worth the effort.

Two Questions They Ask Before Every Decision

In a small district, you can't do everything. Capacity is finite. People already wear three hats. So when something new comes up: a grant opportunity, a new initiative, a policy shift, Amanda's team runs it through two questions.

Is this truly best for students? Does this support the people doing the work?

Both matter. Neither overrides the other.

"Not every initiative serves the same purpose. The key is recognizing the impact on both groups before moving forward," she says. "If an initiative demands significant time and energy from our teachers or administrators, we have to be clear about the return on that investment."

She points to the Texas Incentive Allotment as a real example. Implementing TIA required a lot of paperwork, systems alignment, and administrative monitoring. She knew it would stretch her team. But once they determined it would meaningfully reward effective teaching and invest directly in staff, they committed to it. And then adjusted responsibilities to make it work, rather than just adding it to an already full plate.

The logic is simple: say yes to the right things. Say no to the rest. When everyone shares ownership of that filter, you get focus instead of fatigue.

Where AI Actually Fits In (And Where It Doesn't)

Amanda is honest that AI is still a new territory for her district. They're learning as they go. But the lens they're using to evaluate it is the same lens they use for everything else.

"Work smarter, not harder," she says. "We are not interested in adopting tools simply because they are trending. Any technology, including AI, must serve a clear purpose."

So what does that look like in practice? Tasks like meeting notes, conference transcripts, drafting emails, and creating visuals for campus events. Things that used to eat up hours after a long day.

"Tasks that once required extended time after hours can now be streamlined, allowing us to focus more energy on people rather than paperwork."

Teachers are starting to explore it in the classroom too. Generating activities tied to a specific standard, building presentations from their input, and giving students writing feedback in real time. The guardrail is clear: students produce their own original work. But having something that acts like a patient tutor, flagging patterns, and modeling improvement? That's useful in a district where one teacher often manages lots of kids at once.

Amanda believes finding the balance is key. AI doesn't replace good teaching and strong leadership. When used thoughtfully, it buys back time. And in a small district where everyone is already stretched, that matters.

What She'd Actually Tell Other Leaders

When asked what she'd pass on to someone stepping into a new district, Amanda doesn't lead with strategy. She leads with patience.

"It can be tempting to make immediate, sweeping changes to demonstrate momentum. But lasting change requires trust, and trust takes time. Your first year should be about learning the culture, building relationships, and establishing credibility."

And then, once trust is there, keep building it. Not through speeches, but through keeping your word. Through showing up the same way every day, whether it's going well or not.

She also pushes back gently on the idea that leadership is about having the answers. What she's found is that the right answer usually already exists somewhere in the room. The job is to ask the question and actually listen to what comes back.

"When you listen intentionally, build trust first, and anchor decisions in a shared vision, progress becomes both meaningful and durable."

What This Kind of Leadership Actually Looks Like

There's no secret playbook or proprietary framework Amanda is working from. Just a clear standard she holds herself and her team to, applied with consistency every single day.

Work hard. Be nice to people. Explain your reasoning. Ask before you announce. Make the tough calls when you have to, and don't make them personal. Plan even when you're buried in today.

In a world full of big ideas about educational transformation, there's something worth stopping on in what Amanda Traylor is doing in a small Texas district. She's not waiting for the perfect conditions. She's building them, slowly, with the people in front of her.

Why TomoClub Is Sharing This Story

At TomoClub, we believe the future of education isn't shaped by big-stage reforms. It's shaped inside schools. By leaders who are steady when things are messy, who ask the hard questions, and who build systems people actually trust.

The Education Hall exists to surface these stories. The kind that includes culture resets, difficult staffing decisions, and learning to use AI one meeting note at a time. These are the realities most districts are living in, and they deserve to be shared honestly.

Amanda Traylor's leadership in her district reflects a kind of work that often goes unnoticed. Which understands that before you improve outcomes, you have to earn the trust of the people doing the work every day. And that kind of leadership is exactly what education needs right now.



Dave Moyer

How Dave Moyer Leads Districts That Have Seen Everything, And Gets Them Moving Anyway

This isn't your typical leadership story, with a framework and a plan.

Dave Moyer's story started with a knife search.

First hour of his first day as an assistant high school principal, having never done any of this before, he had to conduct two searches, one for a knife, one for drugs, and handle a suspension for a special education student who got into a fight, all before lunch.

His first day as a high school principal? Teachers picketing on the front sidewalk. First Cabinet meeting as a superintendent? They were reviewing strike plans. A few months into that same job, Wisconsin Governor Walker signed Act 10, dismantling union bargaining rights and sending thousands of protestors to the Capitol in Madison.

"I've seen a lot," he says. "With that said, every time I think that I've seen it all, there is something new."

That's the thing about Dave Moyer. He's not leading from theory. He's leading from four decades of being thrown into situations that would make most people walk out the door, and figuring out how to move forward anyway. What he's built from all of it is a leadership philosophy that is blunt, deeply human, and surprisingly consistent, no matter the size or shape of the district.

The Coaching Instinct That Changed How He Leads

Before Dave was a superintendent, before he was a principal, he was a coach. And the mindset he developed on the field is the one he still uses in the district office.

In baseball, no player dominates all five skill areas — running, hitting, hitting with power, throwing, and fielding. Nobody does all of it. The coach's job is to build a nine-man lineup that makes the most of what each player actually brings. Cover the gaps, elevate the strengths, and win as a team.

"In education, we become too obsessed with remediating weaknesses and not enough time building on strengths," he says. "I think that I am pretty good at building teams and maximizing the strengths of the people on my team."

That sounds simple. But watch how it plays out in practice. When Dave builds a district leadership team, the first thing he looks for is a principal's experience. Not just any

background, but specifically that one. Because if you haven't been a building principal, he believes you genuinely cannot see what you need to see when you're making decisions that affect those buildings.

"If you have missed that step in your career, it is very hard to truly see the big picture on important issues," he says. "When you are supervising principals or programs that are in their buildings and don't understand their world, it can be problematic. I have seen this repeatedly."

He hires to fill a lineup. Everyone needs to have been on the field.

The Decision That Got Him Death Threats

Some leadership stories are about vision and strategy. Some are about doing something you knew was right and absorbing what came with it.

When Dave was superintendent in a district on the Mississippi River in Illinois, he looked at three elementary schools and made a call most leaders would have avoided. The plan: close the oldest school and a two-section elementary, build a Future-Focused school on the remaining site, and use the boundary changes to create something that didn't exist yet: a dual-language Spanish immersion program.

The two-section school they were closing was 90% Latino and Hispanic. Only half the students who attended it eventually graduated from high school. The new structure, he believed, would give those kids a real shot. Better programming. More access. A different trajectory.

The community didn't see it that way. Not at first.

"Neighborhood schools in urban areas are the lifeblood of those communities, and this decision was not without opposition," he says. They sold the property to a church, which converted it into a true community center — preserving something real for the neighborhood. But in the meantime, Dave received death threats. He had police escorts out of meetings.

All of it, for what he describes as "one of the best comprehensive plans that I have been a part of, or, to be a bit bold, possibly seen in my career as a superintendent."

"It's the way it goes."

That line isn't bitterness. It's just experience. He's been around long enough to know that the right call and the popular call aren't always the same call.

"You're the District" — How He Manages Principals

One of the clearest things Dave has figured out across multiple districts is this: principals who blame the district office for their building's problems are a symptom of a leadership failure, not a staffing one. And he won't let it slide.

"When the narrative is 'the district office this' and 'the district office that' — it's a problem," he says. "Guess what. We're the district. You're the district."

His framework is what PLC practitioners call loose-tight leadership. The non-negotiables are clear: board priorities, district goals, the overall direction. But inside that? Principals own their school improvement plans. They own student growth. They own how their staff meetings run and what feedback looks like in their buildings.

"You have to give them the autonomy to lead this work consistent with the nuances of their buildings. If you don't, you only give them ammunition to abdicate their responsibility to the district office."

He's also honest about what he's walked into most places. Principals who were hired to manage buildings, not improve them. People who never fully understood what learning alongside their staff was supposed to mean. So he doesn't just talk about PLCs — he runs every administrator meeting as one. Whatever he wants principals to do in their buildings, he models at the district level first.

There's another thing he won't do. He refuses to use the word "initiative." Teachers have been conditioned to hear it as a threat. One more thing stacked on top of everything else. "Most school districts add without taking away," he says. "That is NOT fair to teachers or good for students." If he wants something to actually take root, he has to help people see how it connects to what they're already doing — not how it's being added on top of it.

On AI: "It's Not Going Away"

Dave isn't someone who gets swept up in hype. He's seen enough trends come and go to know the difference between a real shift and noise. And on AI, he's pretty clear: it's a real shift.

"It is everywhere outside of school and will be part of life for the foreseeable future. It needs to be part of schools as well."

In his district, they're using it for the stuff that makes the most immediate sense — lesson planning, IEPs, communications, data analysis, presentations. Practical applications. Time savers. His team is learning it, getting more comfortable with it, building it into the workflow.

But the part he's most interested in isn't what AI can do for adults. It's what it can do for students. And what students need to know to use it well. His suggested framework for schools is a red-yellow-green system: no AI, AI for certain purposes, and go for it. Simple categories. Clear expectations. Students learn to ask better questions, edit the output, verify what they're getting.

"I am a fan of keeping things simple. All technological breakthroughs have had pros and cons. We need to have our eyes open, but we should not create hysteria."

That's about as level-headed a take as you'll find. No panic. No uncritical enthusiasm. Just someone who's seen enough change to know that the question is never whether to engage — it's how.

What He'd Actually Tell Someone Who Wants His Job

Dave's advice to aspiring superintendents isn't about leadership models or vision statements. It's more direct than that.

Read. Constantly. He gets daily updates from McKinsey. He pays attention to what's happening outside of education specifically because that's where most real innovation originates. "Sometimes people get to a certain point in their career and, for some mystifying reason, stop reading. You have to keep learning. The learning never stops."

Don't stay in one place your whole career waiting for the right opening. Go somewhere else. See something different. The insular view of what a school can be is one of education's biggest problems, and it usually starts with leaders who never left the district they started in.

Don't skip the principalship. He says this plainly and means it. There's no clean substitute for having done that job.

And then this, which might be the most honest thing he says: "Boards will make or break you. I have a good Board right now. That has not always been the case. You cannot do anything without a good and supportive Board."

No spin on that one. Just the truth.

The Thing That's Stayed Consistent

Across all the districts. All the strike plans and protests and contested school closures and police escorts. All of it.

What's stayed constant for Dave Moyer is the same thing that started in the dugout. Figure out what people do well. Put them where it counts. Don't waste time trying to turn a power hitter into a speedster. Build the lineup that wins.

In a field that has a tendency to chase every new idea while leaving the fundamentals of good human leadership behind, that's a more radical stance than it sounds.

Why TomoClub Is Sharing This Story

At TomoClub, we believe the leaders worth learning from aren't always the ones with the cleanest narratives. Sometimes it's the ones who've been through things most people haven't — and came out the other side with something real to say.

The Education Hall exists to surface exactly these kinds of stories. The ones that include death threats and police escorts. The ones where doing the right thing meant doing the unpopular thing and holding steady anyway. These aren't cautionary tales. They're what sustained leadership under real pressure actually looks like.

Dave Moyer's career reflects a kind of leadership that doesn't get enough attention. Experienced. Unsparring. Deeply principled. The kind that understands you have to be present before people trust you, you have to model the work before you can expect it, and you have to know your lineup before you can build a team. That's what education needs — and that's exactly why his story belongs here.



Darin Brawley

Compton Unified Was Two Signatures Away From State Takeover. Thirteen Years Later, It's a Completely Different District.

LEADERSHIP IN PRACTICE | SUPERINTENDENT SPOTLIGHT

He Walked Into a 58% Graduation Rate, a District on State Watch, and One of the Worst A-G Records in Los Angeles County. Here's What He Built Instead.

A three-time turnaround superintendent on protecting classrooms when budgets collapse, why the principalship is non-negotiable in any real leader's resume, and the one question he asks that ends every debate, about change.

FEATURING Darin Brawley | Superintendent, Compton Unified School District

The numbers Darin Brawley, Ed.D., met with when he first entered the Compton Unified School District were not subtle.

Graduation rate: **58%**. A-G completion rate (the coursework students need to qualify for UC and CSU): **12%**. And the district was one of only two in Los Angeles County being watched for potential state takeover.

The other district? It ended up in state receivership.

Compton didn't.

Today, graduation exceeds **94%**. A-G completion is at **76%**. The College and Career Indicator sits at **72%**, among the strongest in California for any district serving a similar student population.

That's not a small improvement. That's a completely different district.

What changed wasn't a program, a policy or a lucky grant cycle. What changed was how the entire system was structured, led, and held accountable. From the budget room to the classroom. From the superintendent's office to every principal's data chat.

And the story of how it happened is one every school leader needs to read.

He'd Already Done This Twice Before

Before Compton, there was Adelanto.

Before Adelanto, there was Fontana.

As a principal in Fontana Unified, Brawley led the first school in San Bernardino County to exit Year 3 Program Improvement. That's not a small thing. Program Improvement schools are those identified under federal law for consistent unmet performance targets. Getting out of it, especially being the first in the county to do so takes a sustained, systemic effort. He doesn't call it a turnaround. He calls it a systems story. Because that's what it actually was.

"That work was not about a single strategy. It was about building a system: aligning instruction, using data with precision, developing teacher capacity, and maintaining a relentless focus on student outcomes."

When he moved to Adelanto as Deputy Superintendent of Instruction, he scaled that same approach across a whole district.

The result? Adelanto posted the **fastest percentile growth in ELA and math in the entire state of California** during that period.

"That level of growth does not happen by chance. It comes from disciplined execution, clear expectations, and a coherent system where every part of the organisation is aligned to improving teaching and learning."

By the time Compton called, he had already built this system twice. He knew what worked. He knew what the resistance would look like. He knew how long it takes for trust to form when a community has good reasons not to trust the institution leading it.

The third time, the stakes were just much higher.

The Framework That Kept Students Protected When Money Got Tight

Most leaders don't talk about this openly: in a turnaround, fiscal discipline and academic improvement must happen at the same time.

You can't fix the budget first and worry about classrooms later. That's how you lose both. Compton's financial situation was serious enough that the state was watching. Right-sizing the organisation, aligning expenditures to sustainable revenue, and making hard cuts, all of that had to happen while simultaneously rebuilding a system of instruction that actually served students.

Brawley came in with a framework he'd developed years earlier in Fontana, during a budget scare under the Gray Davis administration. A crisis that never fully materialised, but forced the district to think clearly about what they would and wouldn't protect if they had to.

Red: Things you don't cut. Ever. Because the impact on classroom instruction is too direct.

Yellow: Areas where reduction might be possible, but only after carefully weighing the impact on students.

Green: Things furthest from the classroom. Where cuts can happen without hurting what matters most.

"That framework created a common language for decision-making and ensured that every conversation, especially difficult financial ones, remained grounded in what mattered most: protecting the instructional core."

Every hard financial meeting in Compton ran through this filter.

It's how a district can make painful budget calls without quietly gutting the classrooms in the process.

Every Six Weeks, You Bring Your Data. No Excuses.

Once the financial foundation started to stabilise, Brawley turned his attention to the people running the schools.

Not through town halls or memos, but through a very specific structure that he built and ran himself.

Every six weeks, principals and assistant principals gather in small cohorts of four to five. They bring their data. They share what's happening in their buildings. And they're expected to own their numbers.

Feedback runs through a plus/delta process. What's working, what needs to shift? Leaders leave with clear next steps and return six weeks later to show what changed.

"These are not passive updates. They are rigorous, transparent conversations where leaders are expected to own their data, articulate what is working, and identify where adjustments are needed."

The design matters here. Small cohorts mean you can't hide. Four or five people in a room with their data, being asked to speak honestly about what's happening in their buildings, creates a very different culture than a large-group meeting where it's easy to be a passenger.

Running alongside that is what Brawley calls a plug-and-play system: instructional resources built by teachers, tied to state standards, heavy on academic vocabulary.

The result is coherence. Every teacher across Compton sees the same expectations, the same support, and the same standard. And because data conversations happen at every level, nobody waits six months to find out something stopped working.

"Trust is earned, not through words, but through a system that delivers for students and supports the people doing the work every day."

He Has One Question for Anyone Defending the Status Quo

Decisions were met with resistance.

Brawley's move when it happens? He puts students above everything else.

"Resistance to change rarely comes from students. It comes from adults. Students are far more adaptable than we give them credit for."

He's seen it in every district he's led. The adults who are most attached to how things have always been done. The practices that get defended not because they're working, but because changing them is uncomfortable. The long-standing norms that have outlived whatever logic originally justified them.

When those conversations come up, he asks one question. Especially when a practice or policy is being defended more by habit than evidence:

"Would this be good enough for your child if he or she were a student in that classroom, at that school?"

That question strips away the policy language. It makes everything personal. And it's very hard to defend the status quo once the honest answer is no.

"That question cuts through everything: programs, policies, excuses, and rationalisations. It forces an honest reflection on expectations and eliminates the gap between what we say we believe and what we are willing to accept in practice."

This isn't a rhetorical trick. It's the standard. And it's been consistent across every district Brawley has led.

Access Can Take Students From 12% to 76%

Fixing graduation rates takes more than accountability systems. Students need real access to the courses, tools, and opportunities that get them there.

Brawley went after that aggressively.

The **Apple ConnectED grant** brought one-to-one devices and modern computer labs to five schools. The district then expanded to approximately **15 Verizon Innovative Learning Schools** and added **six 5G labs** with Heart of America.

NAF Academies launched at all three comprehensive high schools, supported by RTX, connecting students to computer science and engineering pathways tied to real industries.

Junior Achievement 3DE brought Fortune 500 case studies into classrooms, where students analyse real business problems and present solutions as teams.

These programs didn't come across to students as isolated opportunities. They were built into a coherent strategy to expand what Compton students could access, not just during a special program period, but as part of how their schools operate.

And then there's the middle college story.

During Brawley's hiring interview, a board member asked if he could create a middle college campus. His response:

"I am surprised you don't already have one."

It took a few years to build. But **Compton Early College** has now been running for nine years. A second campus, **CTech**, followed. Students work toward CalGETC completion: up to 60 transferable college units to CSU and UC systems, with the option to graduate holding an associate degree alongside their high school diploma.

A district where A-G completion was 12% thirteen years ago is now sending students to college with a head start.

He Actively Hires People Who Could Replace Him.

Brawley's take differs from most leaders. His goal is to hire people who could eventually take his job.

"I believe my effectiveness as a leader is directly tied to the strength of the people around me."

He's not looking for agreement or demanding loyalty. He wants people who have demonstrated results and are willing to think independently, challenge assumptions, and push back when it matters.

Too many leaders, he believes, surround themselves with weaker voices to maintain control. He does the opposite. He looks for strength, then invests in it.

He puts them in situations that stretch them past their current comfort zone. Experiences that build the judgment they'll need when the next opportunity comes. Because the

opportunity always comes, and he wants the people around him ready for it rather than scrambling to catch up.

"Succession is not something that happens at the end. It is something that is developed every day through intentional investment in people."

The measure of leadership, in his view, is whether the organisation can sustain and advance without you. If it can't, the work wasn't finished.

That's a harder standard than most leaders hold themselves to. It means your job is never just about results when you're there. It's about building something that outlasts you.

What's Hidden Beneath It All

When asked what advice he'd give other superintendents, Brawley doesn't go straight to tactics. He goes to something harder to teach.

Will.

"There is really only one. Looking ahead, they all rest on one essential thing: the will to do what is in the best interests of student learning, no matter how difficult that becomes. Without that will, the rest becomes performative."

He's not dismissing the practical work. Instructional coherence, continuous improvement, and data systems- none of them moves the needle if the leader won't face the conflict that real change brings.

And conflict is coming. Every system that gets rearranged faces resistance. Every expectation that gets raised creates friction. Every staffing decision made in the interest of students has a human cost. The leaders who move districts forward are the ones who don't treat that as a reason to slow down.

"When you truly centre students, the path forward becomes much clearer, and the responsibility to act becomes non-negotiable."

Thirteen years in Compton, and the change he brought speaks for itself.

Why TomoClub Is Sharing This Story

The Education Hall exists to surface stories like this one.

This is the story of near-receivership, a 58% graduation rate, and a leader who showed up with a system, held it through every wave of resistance, and built something that actually lasted.

Darin Brawley's work at Compton Unified is one of the most substantive turnaround stories in California public education. It belongs here because it's real, it's replicable, and it reminds us what sustained leadership actually looks like when it's pointed at the right thing.

Rigorous. Student-centered. Built to last.

Found this useful? Share it with a leader who needs to read it.

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Daniel Ludvigson

Walk Light. Stand True: The Four-Word Leadership Philosophy Daniel Ludvigson Built the Hard Way

LEADERSHIP IN PRACTICE | SUPERINTENDENT SPOTLIGHT

A rural Minnesota superintendent on leading through leadership trauma, why pressure reveals rather than creates character, and the four-word philosophy that kept his people steady when the ground shifted underneath all of them.

FEATURING Daniel Ludvigson | Superintendent, Long Prairie-Grey Eagle Public Schools

The back-to-school staff meeting was already on the calendar.

Then the non-renewal vote happened.

Daniel Ludvigson walked in anyway. His people were watching, and he knew it. How he showed up in that room would set the tone for the entire year, maybe longer. If he came in defeated, that would become the culture.

He stayed his usual self.

"Because it was hard, that's exactly why it mattered. It showed people they could count on me, even when I had every reason not to show up."

That moment didn't come from a training or a framework. It came from years of building something quietly and deliberately that held up when the pressure arrived. To understand what he built and why it held, you have to go back to a small district near the Canadian border and a question he still returns to more than any strategy or theory.

What do people say about you when you're not in the room?

For most leaders, that's a thought experiment. For Daniel, it became reality. He was removed from his role, placed somewhere he couldn't do the work he felt called to do. And instead of spending that time fighting or clearing his name, he watched something happen that completely changed how he understood leadership.

People showed up for him. Some took a real professional risk to do it. Leading with genuine care doesn't just feel good. Over time, it comes back around.

The Kind of Information Small Districts Give You

Daniel grew up in a rural community. He liked the pace and the connection. The fact that you know people and they know you. When budget pressure pushed him toward administration, he landed in Munich, North Dakota, a small district near the Canadian border. Not where he'd pictured himself. But it turned out to be exactly the kind of place that builds a certain kind of leader.

"In a small district, you truly know your students," he says. "You don't just see outcomes; you see growth over time. That experience shaped how I view leadership, and it's deeply personal."

That's the foundation. Everything else is built on it.

The Season That Changed Everything

There's a version of Daniel's story that's easy to tell. Strategic planner. Distributed leadership. Cognia recognition. Second-highest reading growth scores in the state at a high-poverty district. Those things are real, and they matter.

The harder part of the story is what happened when things went sideways.

He describes a period of "leadership trauma", years of sustained misrepresentation that occurred while his work was genuinely resonating with people. That contrast, seeing the impact of leading with clarity while having your character questioned, doesn't just test you. It disorients you. You start second-guessing your decisions, your instincts, your own memory of events.

"What made it most difficult wasn't just the situation. It was the uncertainty. You begin to question your decisions, your instincts, your values, even your memory of events."

He's direct about this because he thinks it's underacknowledged. Leaders who take principled stands in complex environments face this more than anyone admits. The standard advice to stay grounded and trust the process doesn't fully hold when the environment is designed to create doubt.

What actually helped was concrete and a little unexpected. He kept children's drawings close during one particularly difficult period. They came from a benefit held for him. A physical reminder of who he was showing up for. When the pressure mounted, he'd look at them, reset, and come back.

"Negativity revises itself when you don't feed it."

It sounds almost too simple. But watch how he talks about coming back from that season, and you start to see what it actually cost him to stay steady.

What Steady Actually Costs

This is easy to miss about leaders who seem unflappable. Being calm under pressure isn't a personality trait. It's a choice, made repeatedly in moments where reacting would be so much easier.

Daniel's built real physical habits around it. Under stress, he monitors the rhythm of his fingers tapping. If it speeds up, he knows he needs to reset before responding. He keeps a book of quotes with him and touches it in high-stakes moments. He's learned that silence de-escalates faster than words, most of the time.

Not coping mechanisms. A system he built deliberately, before the hard moments came, because he understood something most leaders learn too late.

Pressure doesn't create your leadership. It reveals what you've already built. So the work has to happen before the moment comes, which means the back-to-school meeting after the non-renewal vote wasn't where Daniel decided who he was. It was where he found out he'd already decided, years before.

"Maintaining clarity under pressure isn't about being perfect in the moment. It's about being intentional beforehand, so when the moment comes, you're not deciding who you are. You're acting from it."

What "Distributed Leadership" Actually Looks Like When It's Real

Daniel talks about distributed leadership in a way that cuts through the usual fog. To him, it's simple: a leader creates leaders.

In previous districts, he built committee structures where every staff member had a real role in shaping the direction of the school. Committees covered discipline, professional development, and culture. Their work fed into actual decisions. And this part is critical: he made sure people could see it. Which ideas got adopted, how decisions were made, and what changed because someone spoke up.

That feedback loop is what shifted people from participation to ownership. Once they saw their input actually mattered, people stopped referring to the school as something separate from themselves.

At Elgin-New Leipzig, this approach produced results that are hard to argue with. Second-highest reading growth in the state, in one of the poorest counties. Cognia recognized their strategic planning process and invited them to present at the conference.

But Daniel is clear that the structure wasn't the thing. The ownership it created was.

"When people see that their ideas matter and that their contributions shape outcomes, engagement changes. The work is no longer something being done to them. It becomes something being built with them."

He applies the same thinking to MTSS, to strategic planning, to intervention systems. Not because they're complex. Because they're consistent, visible, and connected to purpose. That combination, he's found, is what makes systems actually stick.

The Four Words His Entire Philosophy Lives In

Ask Daniel to define effective leadership in one principle, and he gives you four words.

Walk light. Stand true.

Both parts matter. Walking light means staying connected to why you're doing the work. Not taking yourself too seriously. Keeping the work human. Without it, leadership gets heavy in the wrong ways. Transactional. Lifeless.

Standing true means knowing what you believe and staying there when it gets hard. Because if you give in to everything, you stand for nothing.

"If you only stand true, you become rigid. If you only walk light, you become directionless. But when you hold both, you create something different. Clarity with compassion. Strength without ego. Leadership that people can both trust and follow."

A staff member told him once, after everything: *"Because you showed up for me, I found the strength to do the same."*

Being on the receiving end of what he'd spent years trying to give others, that landed differently. It didn't erase the difficulty. It put it in context.

That's probably what his legacy will be. Not the test scores, not the conference invitation. The people who found their own steadiness because they watched him find his, in conditions where it would've been easier not to.

Why TomoClub Is Sharing This Story

At TomoClub, we believe the future of education is built inside schools by leaders who show up in the hard moments, not just the easy ones.

Daniel Ludvigson's work at Long Prairie-Grey Eagle reflects a kind of leadership that rarely makes it into case studies. Steady. Principled. Quietly relentless. The kind that understands that before you can improve a school, you have to be someone your people trust when the ground is shifting underneath all of you. That kind of leadership is exactly what education needs right now.

Follow TomoClub for insights from leaders who've been where you are.



Annalee Nutter

How Annalee Nutter's Honest Work Led Her to an Unplanned Leadership Role

LEADERSHIP IN PRACTICE | SUPERINTENDENT SPOTLIGHT

Annalee Nutter, Superintendent, Fort McMurray Public School District | Fort McMurray, Alberta

Annalee Nutter never planned to become a Superintendent. She started out teaching in a northern Indigenous community in Saskatchewan. A decade of that, then a reserve, then Grade 1 and 2 classrooms in Fort McMurray, Alberta. No grand ambitions. No five-year plan pointing toward the top job. Just a teacher who kept saying yes when someone knocked on her door.

But that journey built a leader who, when Fort McMurray faced a full city evacuation from wildfire, then floods, then COVID, then the deaths of two colleagues, then two employee strikes back to back, didn't collapse under it. She built. She listened. She created structures that hadn't existed before and made sure the people in her system felt seen when it all happened.

Annalee is now the Superintendent of Fort McMurray Public School District, and the way she leads is inseparable from the city she leads in. Fort McMurray is the kind of place that tests everything. And the school district she runs reflects someone who learned pretty early that relationships are the only thing that holds a system together when everything else is on fire, sometimes literally.

She Never Planned Any of This

For the first 13 or 14 years of her career, Annalee was focused on one thing: getting better in the classroom.

She trained in Understanding by Design, became an instructional coach, and spent years working with students across grade levels in communities that most teachers never see. From teaching on a reserve in central Saskatchewan to working with diverse learners in the north. It wasn't a resume-building exercise. It was just the work.

"I never had aspirations to become a school administrator, let alone a Superintendent. But I was taught never to let an opportunity pass by. And opportunity knocked on my door several times. Each time, I said, 'Okay, I'll try it.'"

That openness of saying yes before you feel ready shaped everything that came after. Vice Principal to Principal to Assistant Superintendent to Superintendent. Each step was handed to her by mentors who saw something she didn't see in herself.

She's been deliberate about naming that. The women who showed her that leadership wasn't only for men. The male leaders who built relationships in ways that stuck with her. The mentors early in her career who offered feedback that pushed her forward.

"Without their encouragement and feedback, I question whether I would have moved in the direction of school leadership."

What she pulled from watching all those leaders wasn't a management framework. It was simpler than that. You need to be a good listener. You need to be present. You need to lead with empathy and consistency. Without those things, trust doesn't form. And without trust, nothing moves.

That's the lens she carries into everything.

What a Decade of Things That Weren't Supposed to Happen Does to a Leader

Fort McMurray is not an easy place to lead.

In 2016, the entire city was evacuated due to a wildfire. 88,000 people gone overnight. Then a major flood. Then a minor flood. Two more smaller fires. COVID. The unexpected deaths of two fellow leaders. And in Annalee's recent years as Superintendent, two employee strikes back-to-back.

"If I have learned anything in my roles as a Leader, it is to expect the unexpected. Anything can happen and it usually does."

She didn't just learn resilience from this. Annalee's insight goes further. The thing she noticed is that not everyone bounces back the same way. Some people are wired for it. Others aren't. A school system that ignores that difference is going to keep losing people.

"I learned that trauma takes its toll and getting things back to 'normal' is a challenge. We bounced back better each time, we were more flexible and more knowledgeable. But not everyone is as resilient as the next."

So she focused on building a wellness infrastructure. Something developed with staff, not for them. That distinction matters to her. She'll say it more than once.

Then came the labour disruption. Reduced staffing. Difficult decisions around keeping schools safe and functional. Competing priorities. And on top of all that, misinformation was spread on social media, including personal attacks aimed directly at her.

The thing about that moment wasn't the criticism. Leaders get criticized. It was the decision about how to respond when things became personal, when incomplete information was circulating, and when people in the community were already stretched and scared.

She chose consistency over reaction and transparent communication. Key messages were pushed out to school leaders so everyone was saying the same thing. A firm, steady focus on student well-being.

"I learned the importance of remaining calm and measured, particularly when situations become personal. Trust is built through consistency, empathy, and a clear focus on what is best for students."

She didn't learn that from a leadership course. She learned it here, in this city, in real time.

What It Actually Means to Build With People, Not For Them

Fort McMurray is more diverse per capita than Toronto. That's not a figure you'd expect from a northern Alberta city, but it's true. It's a community built by people who came from everywhere, and the schools reflect that.

When George Floyd was killed in 2020, a group led a Black Lives Matter march in Fort McMurray and came to the school district with a question: What are you actually doing to address the diversity in your schools?

Annalee processed what followed carefully. There was already meaningful work happening, but it was scattered. Every school was doing something different. No shared approach. The Board wanted an audit, a real assessment of what existed and what was missing.

The audit became a system. A "We Belong" advisory committee was established. Policy was written. Staff and students were educated. A dedicated staff member was hired to lead the work. Schools were supported in purchasing materials. And any time a community event touched on human rights, racism, or discrimination, the district tried to be visibly present with students and staff showing up, not just watching.

"We have seen a lot of success, but we know this is hard work and will take some time to make changes. Currently, we are piloting a reporting tool at two schools so students can share concerns about racism and discrimination through an online tool."

But "We Belong" is just one piece of how Annalee built listening into the structure of the district. When she stepped into the Superintendent role, she created the first-ever Superintendent's Advisory Group of Students, meeting three times a year to hear directly what was working and what wasn't. She runs a parallel Educators' Advisory Group on the same schedule. And she established an Elders' Council to keep Indigenous perspectives at the table.

Four advisory groups, built intentionally for actual input that shapes decisions.

The most vivid example of what that investment looks like in practice is the Land-Based Learning Camps program. Annalee connected with Elders and Knowledge Keepers in the community, secured grants to cover costs, and created overnight camps where students in grades 10 to 12 can earn one to two credits while learning from Elders on the land. Traditional skills. Indigenous culture. Cooking. Survival. Connection to something older than the school system.

The program now runs three times a year for senior students, with additional seasonal day camps for grades 3 to 9.

The feedback has been unlike anything a test score can measure. Students described the loss of culture in their families and what it meant to get even a piece of it back. The mental health impact of people saying it genuinely helped. A demand that far outpaces availability.

Fort McMurray Public has a very high school completion rate for First Nations, Métis, and Inuit students. Annalee won't point to one cause for that. But she doesn't pretend the Land-Based Learning Camps have nothing to do with it either.

What Actually Keeps Teachers in Fort McMurray

Recruiting and retaining teachers in a northern city is its own challenge. Annalee is refreshingly direct about how the district approaches it.

The salary is competitive, and there's a cost-of-living allowance that adds roughly \$1,000 per month on top of the grid. The recruitment team travels to universities across the country, looking for not just individual teachers but couples, people who might put down roots rather than treat Fort McMurray as a stopover.

But the thing Annalee talks about with real pride is the professional learning structure. The district has 13 Professional Learning Fridays built into the calendar every year. Thirteen

dedicated Fridays of collaborative time, structured around school and division priorities, where teachers work together at the school level, across grade teams, or across the whole division.

"We love to share this information when we are out recruiting, because this does not happen everywhere."

New teachers get even more scaffolding. The day before school starts, they come in to learn about the division. Each new teacher is matched with a veteran teacher at their school and, where possible, a mentor from another school who teaches the same grade. They get three release days to meet, observe each other in classrooms, and figure out how to work together. The mentors receive actual training on what to expect.

It's a lot. And it reflects something Annalee has believed since her early career as an instructional coach: professional development isn't a reward. It's what makes the job sustainable.

She also never turned down a request backed by data, research, or evidence of impact. Robotics programs. Environmental studies. Arts initiatives. Things that started as one teacher's idea and grew into something the whole system could point to. "Innovating new programs or processes often leads to others," she says, "and these are all missed opportunities for our students if we don't at least try them."

Thirty Years of Saying Yes

There's a version of Annalee Nutter's story that focuses on her résumé. Teacher to instructional coach to administrator to Superintendent. A clean arc with promotions at each step.

But that version misses the point.

What she actually built over 30-plus years, in communities that tested her in ways most educators never face, is a way of leading rooted in something unglamorous: showing up, listening, being consistent, and trusting that relationships compound over time the same way debt does.

Fort McMurray is not the easiest place to stake a career. It's remote. It's been through things. It keeps asking more of the people who stay.

And the school district Annalee leads reflects someone who understood that before you can move a system forward, you have to know what's holding people back. Not just in theory. In the specific. The specific student who doesn't feel like they belong. The specific teacher who needs a mentor, not a manual. The specific community member who just wants to know the Superintendent is listening.

That's the work. Most of it is invisible. All of it is necessary.

Why TomoClub Is Sharing This Story

At TomoClub, we believe the future of education isn't built by flashy reforms or bold announcements. It's built inside schools and districts by leaders who stay when the pressure is real, who listen before they act, and who build structures that outlast the crises that test them.

Annalee Nutter's work at Fort McMurray Public School District reflects a kind of leadership that often goes unrecognized. Grounded. Relational. Quietly persistent. The kind that understands that before you improve outcomes, you have to build trust and that trust only comes from being consistent when it costs you something. That kind of leadership is exactly what education needs right now.



Liam Dawson

How Liam Dawson's 90-Day Rule Is Changing the Way Districts Trust Their Leaders

LEADERSHIP IN PRACTICE | SUPERINTENDENT SPOTLIGHT

A Minnesota superintendent on why the first 90 days should have nothing to do with strategy, what actually happens when you stop adding programs and start aligning them, and the three-phrase philosophy that keeps his entire district pointed in the same direction.

FEATURING Liam Dawson | Superintendent, St. James Public Schools ISD#840

New programs every semester, making committees for everything, and strategic plans that fill binders nobody opens make a district look impressive and busy on paper.

Liam Dawson has seen that version. And he's spent years doing something harder.

As Superintendent of St. James Public Schools ISD#840 in Minnesota, Dawson has built his leadership around a deceptively simple idea that, before you can improve anything, you have to understand what's already there.

The data and the org chart matter. But also the actual texture of the place: what people believe, what they're worried about, and what they've stopped saying out loud.

That sounds obvious. But in a world where superintendents are under constant pressure to show results fast, it takes real discipline to slow down long enough to really listen.

The Road From Classroom to Central Office

Dawson didn't start in a central office. His journey began in the classroom, and he spent years as a building principal, including leading Northside Elementary through the Minnesota School of Excellence process. That experience shaped the way he thinks about change.

"As a building principal, I learned that the most impactful change happens closest to the classroom. Through strong relationships, high expectations, and clarity of purpose."

It's something he had to learn: that you can have a great vision for a school and still fail if the people inside the building don't share it. Or don't understand what they're supposed to do differently on Monday morning.

When he moved into the superintendent role, the challenge got bigger. Now he wasn't thinking about one school. He was thinking about how decisions around staffing, finance, curriculum, and community engagement all connect to what happens for kids in classrooms. And how to make those connections real, not just conceptual.

His guiding philosophy took shape around three phrases: Listen Deeply. Lead Purposefully. Grow Together.

He Listened for 90 Days Before He Changed a Thing

When Dawson steps into a new district, his first move isn't a strategic plan. It's listening sessions.

Days 1 through 30: he talks to staff, students, families, and community partners. He reviews data and past initiatives. He's not trying to fix anything yet. He's trying to understand what he's actually dealing with, because the stated problem and the real problem are usually different.

Then, between days 30 and 60, patterns start to emerge. What's working, what's been broken for a while, and what everyone knows but is hesitant to say clearly. That's when he starts communicating those themes back out, not as solutions, but to show people he actually heard them.

"Listening builds credibility. Early, focused action builds momentum."

The early action, when it comes, is targeted. A few focused areas are tied to instruction, culture, or communication. A few things, done with intention.

This matters because district change efforts fail constantly, and usually not because the ideas are bad, but because people never bought in. The change was announced, not built. Dawson's 90-day approach is partly about gathering information. But it's really about earning the right to lead.

What Student-Centered Actually Means When It Costs Something

This past winter, two students at St. James wanted to participate in gymnastics. The program cost didn't make financial sense for just two athletes. The easy call would've been to say no.

Instead, Dawson did what he always does. He listened first, understood the priorities, and looked at what was non-negotiable. Then his team started exploring whether a cooperative agreement with surrounding districts could make it work.

It came together faster than expected. And Dawson is the first to admit the communication could've been smoother, given the rushed timeline. But the students got to compete.

"The key was being clear, transparent, and remaining student-centered."

That story might seem small. But it illustrates something that runs through everything he does: the process isn't bureaucratic cover. It's how you make sure the decision actually reflects what the district is supposed to stand for.

The same thinking applied to literacy at Northside. When reading scores were inconsistent across classrooms, the instinct for many leaders would be to add something like a new program, another intervention layer. Dawson's team did the opposite. They looked at what was already there and asked whether it was actually aligned.

The answer was no.

So they focused on three things. High-quality instructional materials, consistent instructional practices, and targeted professional development. They built common assessments to track progress and embedded coaching directly into the schedule, not added on top of all the existing workload.

"The key was not adding more. It was aligning what we already had into a coherent system."

Early literacy proficiency went up. Variability between classrooms went down, all because things that already existed finally talked to each other.

Coffee Hour With the Superintendent

What stands out about Dawson is not just the talk about community engagement, but the structure he built to show for it.

Community Saints and Sips is a monthly coffee hour with the Superintendent, low-key, open to anyone. It's not a town hall or a press event. Just a chance for community members to sit down with the person running their school district and actually talk.

The format sounds simple, but the intent behind it is serious. Dawson uses these conversations the same way he uses staff one-on-ones and student feedback: as a foundation for decision-making. A way to keep hearing what he might otherwise miss once you're far enough up the org chart.

Inside the buildings, there's something equally concrete. Every Wednesday, teacher teams get 90 minutes of protected collaborative planning time. No interruptions, no competing priorities. That's when they look at student work together and figure out what to do next.

"Growth is not top-down. It's collective and continuous."

That could sound like something you put on a motivational poster. But when you see the structures he's built around it, the weekly planning time, the building and district leadership teams, the community coffee hours, it becomes clear he actually means it.

There's even a 10th Grade Chefs program where students partner with the school's Food Service provider to select, order, and create the lunch menu at the middle-high school. Each group throughout the trimester gets a turn preparing a meal for their classmates. That kind of thing doesn't happen by accident. It happens when a leader is genuinely looking for ways to give students real ownership.

The One Area Where He's Choosing to Go Slow

Ask Dawson about artificial intelligence in schools, and his honest answer is that the district hasn't figured it out yet.

And that's intentional.

"This is an area our district is being intentional with. So that we don't rush to make a decision. This one will take time to formulate before implementation."

In an era when districts are scrambling to announce AI policies, that kind of patience is rarer than it should be.

His framework is straightforward. AI in teaching could mean more personalization and efficiency, but only with strong instructional frameworks and clear guardrails around it. AI in leadership could mean better data analysis and decision support.

For students, the real question isn't about the tools at all. It's about the skills they'll need to understand it better. Critical thinking, adaptability, and ethical judgment.

"The goal is not to chase technology, but to leverage it to enhance learning and opportunity. AI should not be utilized as a crutch."

What he's describing is the same approach he applies to everything else. Start with purpose, figure out the professional learning, set clear guidelines, and then implement. The schools that rush AI because it's the next big thing will face the same problems they've faced with every previous wave of innovation. Implementation without infrastructure, change without clarity.

This Is What Patient Leadership Does

Big announcements, bold pivots, and visible drama are glamorous for some leaders. And there are kinds of leaders who quietly build things that hold.

Liam Dawson is the latter.

His work at St. James ISD#840 isn't about chasing the next idea. It's about getting the fundamentals right and then protecting them. Making sure teachers have time to collaborate. That the community has a seat at the table. And the two kids who want to do gymnastics actually get to compete.

The 90-day listening approach, the literacy realignment, the cooperative athletics agreement, and the patient approach to AI, none of it is accidental. It all comes back to a system of values that's been stress-tested across roles, schools, and years.

"When you listen deeply, you uncover the real work. When you lead purposefully, you create clarity. And when you grow together, you sustain impact."

That's not a three-part formula. It's a description of how change actually works in schools. Slowly, through relationships, and with a lot of patience.

Why TomoClub Is Sharing This Story

At TomoClub, we believe the future of education isn't built by announcements. It's built inside school systems by leaders who do the quiet, careful work of alignment, and who keep students at the center even when it's inconvenient.

Liam Dawson's work at St. James Public Schools ISD#840 reflects a kind of leadership that rarely makes the news. Patient. Systems-driven. Genuinely community-rooted. The kind that understands that before you can improve outcomes, you have to align what's already there, and that building shared understanding isn't a soft skill, it's the actual job. That kind of leadership is exactly what education needs right now.

Follow TomoClub for stories from leaders doing the real work in real schools.

